

round, followed by two the second round, and four on the third round until all the mists are engaged.

The oinoloth's orders to the mists were to destroy any creature that tries to fly away from the island. If a flying creature returns to the surface, the vampiric mists stop attacking, hovering above the creature for a few moments before returning to the fog.

If any of the vampiric mists are destroyed, they don't refresh. Only the *censer of blood* can create more.

A flying character who explores near the center of the fog notices that it appears to thicken at that center, congealing into a strange, disc-like black shape roughly 6 feet in diameter, hanging 50 feet above the island. The disc feels soft to the touch and can be grabbed. A strong yank pulls it out of the air and into the character's hands, causing the fog to instantly dissipate. If this happens by day, sunlight shines upon the island, causing the deaths of any remaining vampiric mists within 3 rounds. The disc is the *handkerchief of darkness* (see the "New Magic Items" appendix).

BODIES REVEALED

The actions of the skull lord and other creatures within the floating cube cause it to periodically rotate, exposing new faces of the island while dunking others. When this happens, the freshly exposed face initially appears covered with the dead. But as the Styx water that soaks the bodies evaporates, the curse seeps out of the cube to gradually transform the dead into the pixelated terraces. The full conversion takes about 4 hours, during which time the in-transition terraces slowly lose the appearance of the bodies they truly are.

While fully under the effect of the curse, the features of the bodies can't be discerned, but they retain their true texture—bronze, iron, bone, and flesh, reshaped into perfect cubes. Walking over the island is an awkward and disturbing task, as the 'ground' slips around in large discrete chunks (bodies tumbling about) and randomly changes texture from hard and metallic to soft and squishy.

Submerging the bodies or their gear in the Styx sea unpixelates them. But unless they are immediately removed from the island, the dead quickly become reinfected, showing signs of pixelation within 10 minutes and becoming completely repixelated within 1 hour.

The bodies show no signs of being nibbled by fish (which are repelled by the Styx sea) or gulls (which have been attacked by the vampiric mists and now give the island a wide berth). Though the dead are uniformly gray and cold, they are not currently rotting, as the Styx sea both preserves them and covers up their smell. A successful DC 20 Wisdom (Perception) check allows a character to sniff out the cloaked smell of slow decay.

SEARCHING THE BODIES

Searching the bodies is effectively impossible when they are pixelated. Unless a character is completely pixelated or wearing *pixel glasses*, the bodies are a mosaic of rock, metal, and cold squishy substances with occasional detachable metallic cubes or rectangles.

The bodies can be easily searched while submerged (though doing so brings characters into contact with the Styx sea), or when they have freshly risen from the water. Once exposed to the air, a body repixelates slowly over 4 hours.

The majority of the bodies are human, though occasional duergar, gnomes, dragonborn, and hobgoblins are found among them. All are adults, and represent countless peoples and cultures (including many from remote portions of the multiverse, which the characters won't recognize). Most are naked, while others bear weapons and wear the armor of foot soldiers. With a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) or Intelligence (Medicine) check, a character discerns that though the armored bodies show signs of having died in battle, the naked bodies appear to have died from massive blunt trauma such as a high fall. Moreover, the bodies that have died from falling have not been dead as long as the warriors—including many bodies that look fresh.

If the characters want to search the bodies for valuables, let each character attempt a DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check. On a success, the character finds some object of value, as you determine.

If the characters use *speak with dead* to talk to any of the bodies, what they learn depends on whether they interrogate a naked or armored body. The armored warriors remember being soldiers of Acheron, serving in Cube 1717 under Earl Andromalius, and then being overwhelmed by the pixelating curse and killed by yugoloths. The naked dead have no memories other than appearing in the soul tap in area 6.14 and falling to their deaths.

A FAMILIAR FACE

If the characters search the bodies long enough, have one character notice a disturbingly familiar body: an exact duplicate of an evil enemy the party fought and killed in the past. The dead enemy is recognizable by their facial features, but is wearing new armor and wielding new weapons. Any death wounds the characters remember having dealt to the enemy are gone, with new fatal wounds taking their place.

This fallen warrior is the same enemy the characters killed, reborn in Acheron after death to fight eternal battles for the lords of that plane. Caught in the pixelating curse, the villain then died again in the battle with the yugoloths.

RANDOM SURFACE ENCOUNTERS

Each time the characters arrive on a new face of the cube (including when they first come to the island), each time they finish a short or long rest on the surface of the island, or whenever they spend 1 hour or more exploring the surface, roll a d6. On a roll of 1, use the table below to determine what the characters encounter. All these creatures appear in *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes*.

If the characters are on face 5, ignore all results except 1 or 2. The cadaver collector is strong enough to pass across that face without fear of its residents, and the berbalang has authority over those residents. The other creatures of the cube avoid the beautiful island.

d6	Encounter
1–2	1 cadaver collector
3	1 berbalang
4	1 derro savant and 1 gray render
5	1d3 + 1 white abishai
6	1d4 + 2 bronze scouts

Cadaver Collector. Having survived the fall from Acheron, a **cadaver collector**^M now roams the surface of the cube looking for victims. Unaffected by the Styx sea, this deadly construct emerges from the water to look for prey, then reenters the water after crossing the upper face of the cube. Constantly passing through the water has left the cadaver collector and its load of bodies unpixelated, though it might gather pixelated dead to add to its collection while the characters watch. It attacks any creatures on the cube's surface, but won't pursue prey through the doors.

Berbalang. Bunch the **berbalang**^M (unpixelated; see area 6.13) goes to the surface to scavenge skulls and bones. It ignores the characters unless forced to talk to them, and runs for the nearest door if attacked.

Derro Savant and Gray Render. Avnas the **derro savant**^M and her faithful pixelated **gray render**^M, Moxon, are searching the dead for magic and trinkets she might use in her work. See area 6.17 for more information.

White Abishai. This group is on an expedition from the temple of Tiamat (area 6.38), looking for a way off the island or for potential sacrifices. The **white abishai**^M attempt to capture the characters' ship if they can, or to knock the characters unconscious and drag them back to be sacrificed to their goddess.

Bronze Scouts. The **bronze scouts**^M from face 2 wander over and around the unfortunate dead, attempting to lay them to rest according to their programming, but stymied by their sheer numbers. They approach to within 5 feet of the characters to inspect them, but do not attack unless attacked first. Roll a d6 each time the bronze scouts appear. On 1–3, they are pixelated. On 4–6, they are unpixelated, having just emerged from one of the cube faces presently underwater.

PERMANENT LOSSES

If the **berbalang**, the **derro**, the **gray render**, or any **abishai** are permanently killed, remove them from their home locations. The **cadaver collector** has no permanent home, but is also not replaced if destroyed. Only the **bronze scouts** can reappear indefinitely.

WHEN THE CUBE ROLLS

In addition to the chance for random encounters, whenever the characters finish a short or long rest on the surface of the island or spend 1 hour or more there, have one player roll a d20. On a 10 or less, the cube suddenly begins to move as if roiled by an earthquake. Its current face tilts down into the water along one edge, and a new face rises above the surface, ascending hundreds of feet into the air before plunging down in an enormous spray of water. Roll a d6 to determine which face comes up, ignoring the current face.

Avoiding being dunked into the Styx sea is most easily accomplished by quickly moving to and opening a door into the cube, by flying (though characters doing so will be attacked by the vampiric mists), or by running toward the rising face as the cube turns. Characters who run along the tilting cube discover that each face of the cube has its own gravity. Even when a face is tilted nearly 90 degrees in the moments before it plunges into the water, creatures can move along its surface as if it were level ground. However, the violent motion of the twisting cube can easily toss creatures into the water.

Each creature running across the tilting cube must make three DC 15 Strength (Athletics) checks. A creature that succeeds on at least two checks reaches the next face safely, while all creatures that fail two checks are plunged into the water. A creature that ignores difficult terrain or whose speed is greater than 30 feet has advantage on all three checks.

When a new face of the cube is exposed, the formerly submerged side remains temporarily affected by the curse-removing effects of the Styx sea, letting the characters see the surface of the cube in its true form: a vast expanse of waterlogged bodies. The dead repixelate over the next four hours, giving the characters time to easily inspect them if they choose to.

If the characters watch the island for long enough from their vessel, they might also see the cube roll. Ask one player for a d20 roll whenever the characters finish a long or short rest within view of the island, with the cube rolling on a 10 or less. Though the cube's movement sends waves crashing against nearby ships, characters on those ships are in no danger.

EXPLORING THE CUBE UNDERWATER

Even creatures that can breathe underwater have a difficult time exploring the island's submerged areas, because of the mind-wiping effect of the Styx sea. A submerged creature continually feels the dark power of the water, and must succeed on a DC 15 Intelligence saving throw every minute or suffer its mind-wiping effects.

Underneath the water, the 'landscape' of the cube appears in its true form of iron piled high with the bodies of the dead. A spell such as *Otiluke's resilient sphere* or a magic item such as the *apparatus of Kwalish* can allow the characters to explore the water more easily. However, visibility in the murky Styx sea is limited to 10 feet in any direction.

Even for characters who succeed on their saves or can explore under the water safely, the invisible hydrolaths that guard the island are a deadly threat. Those fiends follow, attack, and kill any creatures in the water unless their attention is distracted by something happening elsewhere.

Any creature that swims within 40 feet of one of the cube's underwater faces feels a momentary dizzy sensation as it's pulled 'down' by the submerged face's local gravity. A creature can easily swim away from the cube's surface (the effect is no stronger than normal gravity), though doing so is mildly disorienting.

The cube's doors won't open on any face that is submerged, and most inhabitants of the cube retreat

inside when the face they normally dwell on is underwater. The only exceptions are the corpse flower of face 4, the bronze scouts and other constructs of face 2, and the cadaver collector that roams all the faces of the cube (see “Random Encounters”). These creatures are unaffected by the Styx sea, and can be encountered by characters exploring under the water.

CUBE 1717

Built as a floating iron fortress in the planar war-world of Acheron, the cube is filled with machinery whose complexity rivals the biology of any living creature. Like a parasite, the Archquadrone plugged itself into the center of that machinery, and the entire cube is now infected by the pixelating curse still pumping from the construct’s heart. The cube cannot operate at full capacity until its ‘brain’ has been fully engaged by the Six-Face Throne. But its autonomic functions still control the internal gravity, the opening and shutting of doors, and the cleanup system that has been disgorging bodies onto the outside of the cube.

If damaged, the cube can heal itself as long as its ‘heart’ beats, slowly generating new, pixelated metal to replace that which was destroyed.

EXTERIOR DOORS

At various points on each face of the cube (except for face 1), a number of metal doors lead into the interior. When the cube is submerged or has freshly risen from the water, these doors appear as 20-foot-wide, 6-inch thick circular metal hatches. At four cardinal points just outside the edge of the door, smaller 1-foot-wide circles are covered with symbolic patterns of law and set with the indentation of a handprint.

The circles radiate abjuration to a *detect magic* spell. If a lawful creature presses its hand into any indentation, the door irises open with a whoosh, revealing a 20-foot-wide shaft with four ladders (one beneath each handprint) leading down. Nonlawful creatures can use the hand of a dead lawful creature (including any of the creatures on the surface) to open the door.

When the characters first come to the island—and within 10 minutes of a cube face emerging from the water—the doors are pixelated. Though the circles are still recognizable, the symbols of law and the handprint appear as boxy, illegible mosaics. While a door is in this form, it opens only when the flesh of a lawful creature is pressed into the door in a cubical shape. Any creatures or bodies on the surface have their hands automatically conform to a cubical shape when they are pixelated. Alternatively, the characters can press, flense, or *polymorph* the flesh of a lawful creature so that it fits the shape.

A *remove curse* or *dispel magic* spell cast upon a pixelated circle causes it to become unpixelated for 10 minutes, allowing it to be used with a normal handprint.

Near the top of each of the four ladders, a pixelated handprint lock operates the door from the other side. The interior of each shaft is lit by glowing pixels in the walls at regular intervals. Like the doors, the shafts are

circular, but show pixelated edges made of numerous tiny cubes. The rungs of the ladders are also square.

When any character passes through the doors—or 10 seconds after opening a door if no character does—square pixel lights in the shaft walls near the doors flash red, a hidden alarm blares, and the doors seal shut. If a lawful creature’s body blocks the door, the door stays open and the red lights continue flashing until the creature moves. The doors close around the body of any other creature, which must succeed on a DC 14 Dexterity saving throw to leap out of the way or take 35 (10d6) slashing damage as the door irises closed on them. A creature reduced to 0 hit points by this damage dies as the door cuts it in two. A creature not killed by the door chooses which side of the door it ends up on.

The doors have AC 20; 100 hit points; a damage threshold of 7; immunity to psychic and poison damage; immunity to bludgeoning, piercing, or slashing damage from nonmagical attacks not made with adamantite weapons; and resistance to cold and fire damage. The first 20 damage dealt to a door opens a small hole in it, just wide enough to let a character look through. Anyone dealing bludgeoning, piercing, slashing, or thunder damage to the doors makes noise that echoes deep into the cube, alerting any nearby guards. As long as the Six-Face Throne is active, damaged or destroyed doors slowly regenerate, returning to their original condition in 1 hour.

JUNCTION ROOMS

By default, each face of the cube has its own local gravity, which is controlled from area 6.28 and extends 40 feet above and below each face. When characters descend deeper into the cube, the gravity from face 6 (the dominant face) takes over. This change in gravity is potentially disorienting—and can be deadly in certain areas.

Several doors on the cube’s surface lead to junction rooms that allow travel from one face to another. Some junctions lead to two faces, while others lead to three. A character who flies, climbs, or falls down the 40-foot shaft to the ‘bottom’ of the junction room lands in what seems to be the bottom of a 20-foot-wide well-like space, which features two or three identical 20-foot-wide shafts leading up. Each shaft has ladders on its four sides, like most of the corridors inside the cube.

The special gravity of the cube combines with illusion magic to make the ‘floor’ of each junction room appear to be down. All the shafts leading out seem to lead up, even though the different shafts lead to different cube faces that are perpendicular to one another. This odd effect causes all nonpixelated creatures to have disadvantage on attack rolls while in a junction room.

MOVING THE CUBE

Characters who climb down one shaft into the junction room, then climb up another shaft leading onto a different face find themselves under one of the exterior doors, with four pixelated handprint circles controlling the door from the inside. However, if any of these circles are activated, the opening of the door is delayed by